

# Federal ICR Items 12-15 Benchmark

## *Findings and Recommendations for TSA Economic Analysis*

September 9, 2026

### Executive summary

A review of 73 recent federal Information Collection Requests (ICRs), including ten TSA collections, supports five findings for Economic Analysis Branch leadership.<sup>1</sup>

- 1. Strong federal practice is distributed.** No single reviewed agency supplies the complete model. Useful methods combine explicit burden activities, supported labor valuation, clear cost boundaries, and quantified explanations of change.
- 2. TSA has meaningful strengths, particularly in Item 12.** Reviewed collections distinguish activities, applicant and employer effort, transition cohorts, and occupations. Several also expose Federal workload equations. Preserve these foundations.
- 3. Preventable consistency and reconstruction risks reached publication.** Selected TSA statements contain nonreconciling subtotals and Federal hours, conflicting table and narrative costs, and an applied wage that does not match its footnote. These differences impede reconstruction and reuse of the intended estimate; they are more than presentation defects.
- 4. The principal opportunity is architectural.** One source-bound model should produce the Excel model and all Items 12-15 outputs after arithmetic, unit, period, and pathway checks. The value is one analytical source of truth producing every downstream representation. Human review remains responsible for the validity of assumptions and cost scope.
- 5. Federal examples provide concrete methods to adopt.** An obligation ledger can prevent counting work already assigned elsewhere; measured burden should include preparation; purchased services should be separated from internal effort; and Item 15 should quantify changes from a named baseline.

**Recommended next step.** Establish common QA controls and sponsor a bounded prototype on one upcoming TSA collection. Require source-to-output traceability and reconciled outputs before expanding. Then use the reviewed corpus to compare assumptions across similarly shaped TSA collections.

The evidence establishes published reconstruction risks, not their internal causes. Detailed methodology, benchmark results, and technical appendices are retained separately.

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1. *Benchmarking Federal ICR Burden and Cost Analysis: Best Practices for Supporting Statement Items 12-15.* (2026). [Technical report]. Executive summary; sections 2, 9-10.

# 1. Why this matters

Items 12-15 describe connected parts of an estimate: respondent time and labor valuation, non-hour respondent costs, Federal costs, and changes from the prior estimate. A reader should be able to move between these parts without encountering different populations, incompatible periods, or conflicting totals.<sup>2</sup>

For TSA, the value extends beyond preparing a Supporting Statement. Burden and cost inputs may be reused in economic, policy, program, and regulatory analysis. When the published estimate cannot be reconstructed, the next analyst must resolve ambiguities before deciding whether the estimate is suitable for reuse. That work competes with substantive analysis for scarce branch capacity.

Repeatable methods can reduce that reconstruction burden. A renewal should reveal which requirements, populations, times, wages, or prices changed and how those changes affect the estimate. It should not require rediscovering the relationship between a narrative number and a separately maintained table.

## What the evidence can tell leadership

The benchmark reviewed **73 unique recent controls across 38 agency/component labels**, with TSA as the focal application. Its principal quality lens was independent reconstruction: can a reader follow disclosed inputs and assumptions to reported outputs? The review examined public statements and supporting materials and replayed selected calculations.<sup>3</sup>

This was a purposive search for useful methods and counterexamples, not a representative sample. Scoring was performed by one analyst. The results support learning from particular methods and identifying documented inconsistencies; they do not estimate an agency-wide error rate or government-wide ranking.

**Confidence is strongest where the evidence is directly observable:** displayed components and totals, quoted rates, footnote transformations, and described activity structures. Confidence is more limited where the intended scope, internal precision, administrative inputs, or production history are unavailable. Some reviewed packages were pending, so public availability does not imply final approval.

The branch can act on this evidence without resolving every uncertainty. Arithmetic and representation checks are appropriate even when the intended replacement value remains unknown. Substantive questions about populations, timing, and cost boundaries should remain visible for analyst resolution.

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2. Office of Information and Regulatory Affairs. (n.d.). *Creating a Supporting Statement Part A*. [Published source](#). Items 12-15, pp. 2-3.

3. *Federal ICR technical benchmark*. Sections 1-3; Appendix E.

## 2. What the benchmark found

### A practical federal frontier

The table identifies transferable methods that improve reconstruction. Each example teaches a bounded practice; it does not validate the collection's entire estimate.

| Area             | Strong practice                                                   | Useful example and TSA application                                                                 |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Burden structure | Distinguish activities and obligations already counted elsewhere. | BLS occupational injury survey: distinguish existing and newly induced recordkeeping. <sup>4</sup> |
| Labor valuation  | Disclose occupation choice, wage basis, and compensation method.  | TSA flight training: retain career-stage rationale and wage/benefits sources. <sup>5</sup>         |
| Item 13          | Separate work done internally from purchased services.            | OSHA extinguishers: quantities and make-or-buy structure prevent double charging. <sup>6</sup>     |
| Federal cost     | Connect workload, time, and compensation.                         | TSA aircraft operators: distinct workloads support attributable resource costs. <sup>7</sup>       |
| Item 15          | Link a named change to a quantified effect.                       | Coast Guard security plans: removed addendum responses translate into fewer hours. <sup>8</sup>    |

A common model should preserve operational differences. An estimate can reproduce exactly while its population, time, or wage proxy remains unsupported. Adoption therefore requires both reconstruction and fit to the TSA collection.

4. Bureau of Labor Statistics. (2024). *Supporting statement A: Survey of Occupational Injuries and Illnesses*. (OMB Control No. 1220-0045). [Published source](#). Item 12, recording burden and Table 9.

5. Transportation Security Administration. (2024). *Supporting statement A: Flight Training Security Program*. (OMB Control No. 1652-0021). [Published source](#). Item 12, wage-selection footnotes.

6. Occupational Safety and Health Administration. (2024). *Supporting statement A: Portable Fire Extinguishers Standard (Annual Maintenance Certification Record) (29 CFR 1910.157(e)(3))*. (OMB Control No. 1218-0238). [Published source](#). Items 12-13.

7. Transportation Security Administration. (2024). *Supporting statement A: Aircraft Operator Security, 49 CFR Part 1544*. (OMB Control No. 1652-0003). [Published source](#). Item 14.

8. U.S. Coast Guard. (2025). *Supporting statement A: Security Plan for Ports, Vessels, Facilities, Outer Continental Shelf Facilities and Other Security-Related Requirements*. (OMB Control No. 1625-0077). [Published source](#). Item 15, removal of CG-6025A.

## 2. What the benchmark found

### Three methods worth transferring first

**Assign obligations before adding hours.** The BLS example distinguishes establishments already required to keep OSHA records from those newly required to keep records for the survey. The transferable principle is to identify who already bears an obligation and where it is counted. For TSA, an obligation ledger should identify the responsible control and explain exclusions or transfers. Shared requirements should not become duplicated burden merely because they appear in more than one analytical view.<sup>9</sup>

**Measure the whole task.** Census's Annual Integrated Economic Survey testing distinguishes preparation, questionnaire-reported estimates, and paradata. These observations differ in scope and statistic. Time spent in an instrument does not necessarily include preparation, coordination, or record retrieval; a median cannot silently stand in for a mean. TSA timing evidence should identify the activity measured, respondent segment, observation period, and statistic before it is used to validate a burden assumption.<sup>10</sup>

**Make Item 15 a numerical explanation.** The Coast Guard security-plan example removes 980 two-minute addendum responses, or approximately 33 annual hours. This is useful because the change in a requirement is linked to an interpretable workload effect. Its underlying administrative query is unavailable, so the example teaches reconciliation rather than complete replication of every input.<sup>11</sup>

For TSA, retain a named prior baseline and a separate explanation of changes in responses, hours, and nonlabor dollars. A change in population, task time, collection requirements, or estimation method should have an identifiable effect. When multiple inputs change together, disclose how their joint effect is allocated rather than silently switching the comparison basis.<sup>12</sup>

### Transfer methods; revalidate assumptions

Do not import another collection's time, wage, price, or allocation share merely because its method is transparent. OSHA's purchased-service structure, for example, is useful even when consultation age and cost scope require fresh review for a TSA application.

These practices improve different parts of the same estimate: the obligation ledger defines what is counted, measurement supports the amount of work, and the change bridge explains why the result moved. They are complementary controls, not alternative templates.

9. Bureau of Labor Statistics, *Survey of Occupational Injuries and Illnesses*. Item 12, recording burden and Table 9.

10. U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *Attachment N - AIES Dress Rehearsal Preliminary Findings and Recommendations*. (OMB Control No. 0607-1024). [Published source](#). Printed p. 19, burden measurement comparison.

11. U.S. Coast Guard, *Security Plan Requirements*. Items 12 and 15, removal of CG-6025A.

12. *Federal ICR technical benchmark*. Sections 8, 10 and 14.

### 3. What the benchmark shows about TSA

#### Preserve the strongest analytical structures

Reviewed TSA statements often contain operational detail that a generic burden template would miss. Three examples illustrate what should become reusable branch practice.

**Aircraft Operator Security distinguishes tasks and Federal workloads.** Its respondent model separates 18 activities, while Federal costing identifies three workloads. That structure makes it possible to change a task frequency or review-time assumption without treating the entire collection as one undifferentiated estimate.<sup>13</sup>

**Airport Security distinguishes who performs the work.** Applicant time is separated from airport data-entry effort. Keeping those roles distinct supports occupation selection, prevents a single labor rate from obscuring different tasks, and clarifies when activities are additive even though they concern the same applicant.<sup>14</sup>

**Flight Training Security models a transition rather than a flat population.**

Year-specific candidate and provider cohorts reflect movement to a multiyear security threat assessment. Its wage discussion also explains a career-stage choice and identifies wage and benefits sources. These are substantive modeling choices that a common structure should preserve.<sup>15</sup>

Flight training received 52 of 60 points on the study's Item 12 composite, close to the highest observed 53. This supports the assessment of its reviewed method, not an agency ranking.<sup>16</sup>

#### Standardize the connections, not just the template

A useful common approach would retain these distinctions and link them consistently: the activity to its population; the task to its occupation and rate; the cohort to the correct year; and the Federal workload to the appropriate resource cost.

The examples on the next two pages show why those connections matter. Detailed analytical structure can coexist with conflicting published representations. Preserving the structure while strengthening reconciliation is more useful than replacing it with a simpler, less informative narrative.

13. Transportation Security Administration, *Aircraft Operator Security*, 49 CFR Part 1544. Items 12 and 14.

14. Transportation Security Administration. (2025). *Supporting statement A: Airport Security Part 1542*. (OMB Control No. 1652-0002). [Published source](#). Item 12, STA applicant and airport data-entry activities.

15. Transportation Security Administration, *Flight Training Security Program*. Item 12, cohort tables and wage-selection footnotes.

16. *Federal ICR technical benchmark*. Sections 3, 5 and 9.

### 3. What the benchmark shows about TSA

#### Published values do not always reconcile

##### Certified Cargo Screening Program: subtotal discrepancy

**Published issue.** In Item 12, Table 7, the displayed component hours sum to **6,049**, while the published subtotal is **4,451 hours**. The difference is **1,598 hours**.<sup>17</sup>

**Classification.** This is a confirmed discrepancy between displayed components and a displayed subtotal. The source does not establish whether a component, the subtotal, or an underlying version represents the intended estimate. The recomputed sum should not be treated as a certified replacement package total.

**Why it matters.** A downstream analyst cannot use both the component model and the subtotal consistently. Reuse requires resolving which values are intended, even though the table appears to supply the necessary inputs.

**Direct control.** Calculate subtotals from the same underlying activity values used to produce the table. Reconcile displayed totals under a documented rounding rule, and require a disposition when the values do not agree.

##### Aircraft Operator Security: table/narrative conflict

**Published issue.** The first-flight checklist narrative reports annual labor cost of **\$54,658**, while Table 2 reports **\$20,165,327** for that activity. The smaller value also appears for the adjacent foreign-airport employee activity.<sup>18</sup>

**Classification.** This is a displayed-value conflict. The repeated amount does not establish the internal editing history. The table and a recomputation from displayed rates are close but not identical, so the benchmark does not certify a new exact replacement cost.

**Why it matters.** A reader who extracts the narrative rather than the table obtains a materially different estimate for the same activity. A general review of whether the model “looks reasonable” is insufficient to reconcile those representations.

**Direct control.** Bind the narrative amount and table cell to the same validated result. After any revision, regenerate both and check that the final exported statement agrees with the workbook.

17. Transportation Security Administration. (2024). *Supporting statement A: Certified Cargo Screening Program*. (OMB Control No. 1652-0053). [Published source](#). Item 12, Table 7.

18. Transportation Security Administration, *Aircraft Operator Security, 49 CFR Part 1544*. Item 12, first-flight checklist, foreign-airport employees and Table 2.

### 3. What the benchmark shows about TSA

#### Rates and workload require separate checks

##### Airport Security: applied wage and footnote conflict

**Published issue.** Applicant calculations use **\$34.48 per hour**, while the wage-footnote transformation produces approximately **\$50.19 per hour**. The footnote gives a \$34.51 wage and a compensation factor based on \$50.31 divided by \$34.59.<sup>19</sup>

**Classification and significance.** This is a rate/version ambiguity. The applied value and stated transformation conflict; the intended input is unresolved. Substituting the higher value would exceed the evidence.

**Direct control.** Retain the source wage, compensation ratio, transformation, and applied value together; generate the footnote from those inputs. Analysts must resolve conflicts.

##### Surface Cybersecurity: workload and proxy alignment

**Published issue.** The Federal workload rows total **1,149 hours**, compared with **881 hours** reported. Separately, the contact-update estimate combines an average monthly separations proxy with annual residential mobility. Those inputs differ in period and event definition, and their overlap is unresolved.<sup>20</sup>

**Classification and significance.** The total is a displayed arithmetic discrepancy; the contact estimate is a source-transformation problem. A residential move need not change a professional contact. The package was pending at retrieval, not an approved final revision.

**Direct control.** Reconcile workload totals mechanically. Separately require compatible periods, explicit event definitions, and a defensible mapping from source population to modeled activity.

#### What the pattern establishes

The benchmark does not establish poor internal models or that manual processing caused these differences. **It establishes that inconsistent representations survived into public documents.** The quality-control implication is that the production approach permits avoidable alignment failures. Separate representations create opportunities for drift; this is an architectural interpretation, not an observation of internal production history.

Possible pathway duplication requires a scope decision; small precision residuals require a rounding check. The technical report retains these distinct additional cases.

19. Transportation Security Administration, *Airport Security Part 1542*. Item 12, applicant wage footnote and CHRC/STA calculations.

20. Transportation Security Administration. (2026). *Supporting statement A: Cybersecurity Measures for Surface Modes*. (OMB Control No. 1652-0074). [Published source](#). Item 14, Table 8; Item 12, coordinator updates and source footnotes.

## 4. What TSA should do

### Prioritize controls that resolve the observed risks

These recommendations translate the findings into branch practice.<sup>21</sup>

| Action             | Priority for Economic Analysis                                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>KEEP</b>        | Preserve task-level activities, applicant/employer distinctions, year-specific cohorts, occupation rationale, and workload-based Federal costing.                                                     |
| <b>IMPROVE</b>     | Validate population partitions and additive tasks; check units, rate periods, transformations, and arithmetic; synchronize tables, footnotes, and narrative; record support for material assumptions. |
| <b>ADOPT</b>       | Use named-baseline Item 15 bridges, a cross-control obligation ledger, burden observations with measurement scope, and explicit internal-work/purchased-service distinctions.                         |
| <b>INVESTIGATE</b> | Resolve purchased-service routing, overhead overlap, Federal system allocations, and proxy validity before imposing common defaults.                                                                  |

### Make the review outcomes explicit

**Population and pathway review.** Distinguish unique respondents from repeated responses. State whether activities are alternatives or additional tasks. Exclusive pathway shares should reconcile; recurring activities should not inflate the count of unique people.

**Source and rate review.** Preserve the source period, population, unit, transformation, and occupation rationale. Review proxy fit and aging inputs explicitly.

**Arithmetic and output review.** Reconcile activity rows, subtotals, and summaries at retained precision. Generate published numbers and source footnotes from the accepted model. After edits, compare the final statement with the model again.

**Assumption and scope review.** Identify unsupported timing or allocation assumptions, distinguish missing information from zero, and separate fee recovery from gross Federal resources. Resolve material scope questions rather than embedding an unexplained convention.

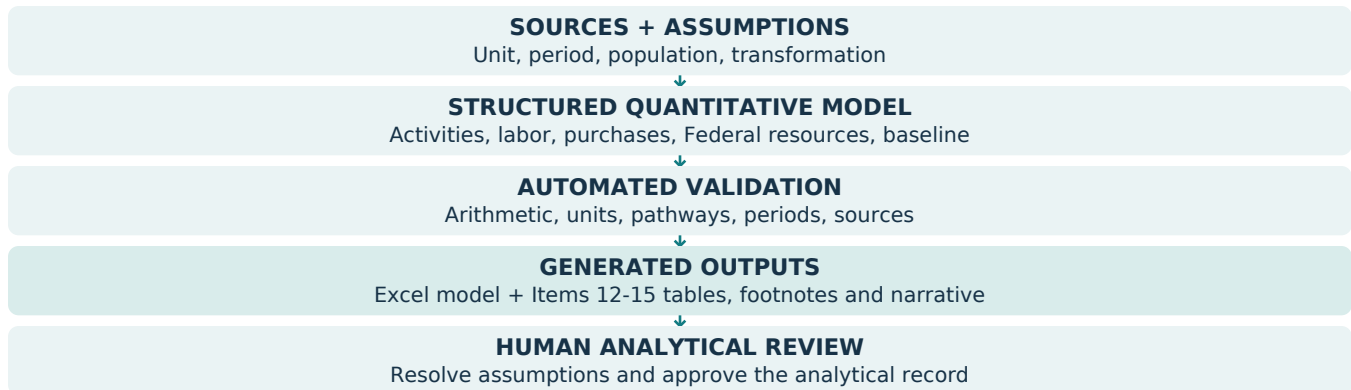
Distinguish failed arithmetic identities from analytical warnings. The former require reconciliation; the latter require judgment and evidence.

<sup>21</sup>. *Federal ICR technical benchmark*. Section 10; sections 13-15.

## 5. The recommended analytical architecture

### One analytical source of truth

A common record should bind each material input to its source, unit, period, population, and transformation, and identify assumptions as assumptions. The resulting model should generate the Excel workbook and the Supporting Statement's quantitative content together.<sup>22</sup>



**Figure 1. Recommended production approach.** Revisions return to the model before outputs are regenerated.

### What the system should check

Automate arithmetic, unit, period, population-partition, and Item 15 checks. Flag potential duplicate pathways and missing or stale sources. Generate numeric prose and footnotes from shared results, then check final exports for agreement.

Common totals address the cargo discrepancy; shared values address the aircraft conflict; source-bound rates address the airport conflict; workload and period checks address the cybersecurity findings.

### What analysts must decide

Population definitions, activity boundaries, task-time assumptions, occupation fit, proxy validity, cost scope, and classification remain human judgments. Software can flag an overlap or unsupported assumption; it cannot determine that the intended population or time is correct merely because an equation balances.

The expected benefit is less reconciliation and more focused review. Savings are unquantified and should be measured in the pilot. Detailed architecture is retained separately.

<sup>22</sup>. *Federal ICR technical benchmark*. Sections 14-15.

## 6. Recommended next steps

### Start with a bounded branch decision

**Near term: adopt common QA controls.** Assign responsibility for a shared review checklist covering populations, rates and periods, arithmetic, output agreement, assumptions, and Item 15. Apply it to an upcoming collection. Record unresolved questions separately from corrected arithmetic so review can focus on the decisions that remain.

**Next: prototype one complete analytical record.** Select a collection with distinct activities, respondent segments, Federal workload, and a usable prior baseline. Use the benchmark-derived model to generate a formula-preserving Excel workbook, tables, rate footnotes, and draft Items 12-15 narrative. Keep the pilot bounded to the selected collection before expanding its scope.<sup>23</sup>

The pilot should demonstrate that a reviewer can trace a published value to its inputs and that changing an input updates every affected output. Require reconciled subtotals, explicit pathway relationships, consistent rate periods, and a quantified baseline bridge. Unsupported assumptions should remain visible for review rather than being replaced with convenient defaults.

**Then: compare assumptions across TSA collections.** Construct an evidence graph linking published sources, obligations, populations, activities, and assumptions. Begin with internal TSA consistency among similarly shaped collections: enrollment, recordkeeping, security-plan amendments, review tasks, and shared systems. Use other agencies secondarily to supply candidate methods and comparison questions.

Differences warrant review, not automatic correction. Preserve task scope, population, mode, period, and evidence quality before standardizing.

**Longer term: integrate creation and review.** Combine validated modeling, evidence retrieval, and documented analytical decisions into a comprehensive ICR creation and review process. Expansion should follow demonstrated output consistency and usability.

### Decide whether to scale on observed results

For the pilot, track analyst preparation and reconciliation time, reviewer questions, traceability of material inputs, and contradictions remaining at final review. Establish a comparison basis before claiming gains; these are proposed success measures.

**Leadership decision requested:** designate an analytical lead, select the pilot collection, and authorize the bounded prototype with the controls above as acceptance conditions.

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23. *Federal ICR technical benchmark*. Sections 10 and 14-16.

## References

Bureau of Labor Statistics. (2024). *Supporting statement A: Survey of Occupational Injuries and Illnesses*. (OMB Control No. 1220-0045). [Published source](#).

*Benchmarking Federal ICR Burden and Cost Analysis: Best Practices for Supporting Statement Items 12-15*. (2026). [Technical report].

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